

Chromebook top-seller on Amazon

According to reports, the new Google Chromebook by Samsung is selling fast on Amazon. You can read more here: <http://digit.in/WODHVe>



Apple store robbed

Apple's store in Paris got robbed of Apple merchandise worth more than \$1 million by masked men

Form factor 101

In a post-PC era, computing devices come in a variety of size and shapes. The consumerization of IT, improved manufacturing processes and innovative industrial design are giving rise to form factors that are giving a fresh lease of life to computing devices

Ours is a life surrounded by computing devices, and they come in different sizes and shapes. Whether it's that old faithful desktop PC which is almost as old as yourself or that latest touchscreen smartphone you finally managed to snag after months of research, how many of us actually stop and appreciate their form? How would you describe a laptop's form and design? Is convertible a term only of interest to grease monkeys and car aficionados? And what is a hybrid device, pray do tell? We try and sort it all out below, giving you a basic understanding of popular consumer tech device form factors.

1) Non-mobile

As you can imagine, since heavy, tied-down computers are part of the old school of computing, nothing extravagant has happened in this segment of personal computing. The transition from ugly, rectangular boxes to sleek, photo frame units can hardly be dubbed revolutionary in the 21st century.



An all-in-one PC! Where'd the cabinet go?!

- **Traditional desktop PC:** There wasn't anything particularly evocative about the parts (cabinet, monitor, keyboard and mouse) that consisted and comprised of a desktop PC. The commercial personal computer as it

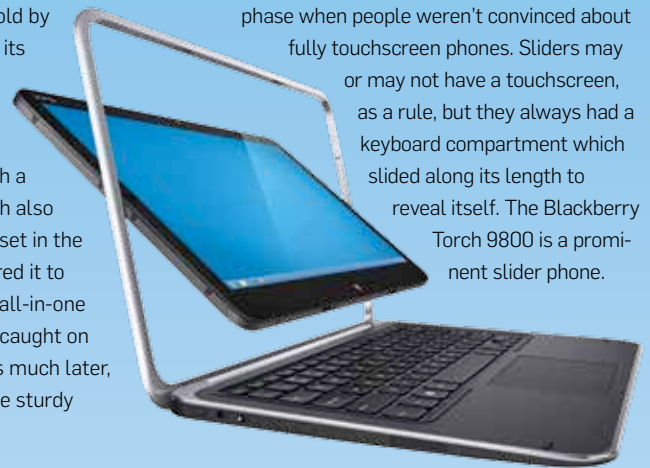
was first packaged and sold by IBM never deviated from its design DNA overmuch, even to this day.

- **All-in-one:** When Apple released its first iMac with a translucent monitor which also housed the system's chipset in the enclosure, many considered it to be a passing fad. But the all-in-one form factor of the device caught on with other manufacturers much later, and today's AIO PC's have sturdy photo-frame like design.

2) Mobile

Predictably, all the action and battle of innovative design is being fought tooth and nail in mobile PCs and handheld computing devices that primarily include laptops, tablets and smartphones. There's a lot of flux in this space of consumer products with the dust being far from settled. Exciting times for sure.

- **Clamshell:** All modern laptops sport this design, including most ultrabooks, where the screen lid of the portable PC and its bottom chassis are held together by hinges – like on a suitcase. Flip phones of the past also fall under this design and form factor.
- **Candybar:** The most dominant form factor among mobile phones. It is basically a cuboid but of different volume, size and shape (for every manufacturer), and apart from buttons it may not have any other moving part. Most QWERTY and touchscreen phones found in the market today embrace this form factor.
- **Slate (tablet):** Just an enlarged Candybar, a smartphone gets into the slate or tablet territory when it starts measuring between 7 to 12 inches.
- **Slider:** A unique form factor, slider phones came into prominence at a transitionary



phase when people weren't convinced about fully touchscreen phones. Sliders may or may not have a touchscreen, as a rule, but they always had a keyboard compartment which slid along its length to reveal itself. The BlackBerry Torch 9800 is a prominent slider phone.

A swivelling screen is the *pièce de résistance* of a convertible's design

- **Convertible:** This is essentially a laptop or notebook form factor which has a swivel multi-touch screen to rotate and sit back on the keyboard, essentially transforming the device into a tablet form factor.



A hybrid form factor makes a conventional clamshell laptop into a tablet with a keyboard dock. Genius

- **Hybrid:** These are smaller notebooks or netbook-like devices with a detachable screen, a natural evolution of the design. With the keyboard attached, the device is a netbook or notebook; but take the screen apart and the screen transforms into a full-fledged tablet. Great, isn't it? 